



Common Challenges in the Alliance with Protectors

WHEN BREAKS IN CONTINUITY ARE FUELED BY PROTECTOR FEARS

Often protective parts try to derail the work by distracting. Remember, they are trying to keep the exile out of mind. If this happens and the client forgets what happened last week or a protector changes the subject to avoid returning to a part from the week before, we treat it as an opportunity.

A PROTECTOR OBJECTS TO CONTINUITY

THERAPIST: I hear you have a part who would prefer not to go back to the part (name or describe the part: the little girl, the little boy, the fluffy bird...) who we were talking to at the end of our last session. Is that right? Would it be willing to say why?

- *If it is worried about the client being overwhelmed by the part from last week, then:*

THERAPIST: I see. That makes sense. I wouldn't want that to happen either. If the little girl (little boy, fluffy bird...) agrees not to overwhelm, would it be okay to talk to her (him, it) again now?

- *If the part says it doesn't seem important anymore, or something else seems much more important, then:*

THERAPIST: I see. But I am curious. Can I ask what is most important about paying attention to _____ (the client's current concern) this week?"

Whatever Happens, Be in Self

If the client replies that the current concern is pressing and needs immediate attention (a decision must be made, a response is required, etc.), then, especially if it doesn't happen all the time, you may choose to follow along.

- Check your Self-energy when you are in this kind of negotiation to be sure you feel Self-led.
- And if you do decide to go along, first ask the client to check in with the target part from the week before to ask how it's doing, get it's permission to shift topics, and set the intention to return to it the next week – and then follow through.

Help Hard Working Protectors

But if the client has a chaotic life that is chronically interrupted by current crises, keep negotiating. In this case, actively selling the generic goal of IFS therapy to the client's protectors (being what Schwartz calls a "hope merchant") can be a good idea.

Hope Merchant

THERAPIST: I have a lot of experience helping clients to help their most vulnerable parts feel better – and then all their hard working protective parts feel better, too.

- *Then validate the fears of the client's protectors.*

THERAPIST (continuing): I know it can be really scary for protectors to let you get near a vulnerable part.

- *And finally reassure.*

THERAPIST (continuing): But we can do this safely. If they are direct with you then we can address each concern. Would they be willing to tell you what the worry is?

Protector Fears

If the part who wants to change the subject remains insistent, it's also a good idea to validate its sense of imperative.

THERAPIST: I know your life still has a lot of ups and downs and many interactions with people today cause you to feel unsafe. You have parts who bring you to therapy to fix this problem. But in their view that does not mean hanging around with parts who feel bad and threaten to overwhelm you. Am I in the ballpark?

If the Answer is Yes

THERAPIST: Do the parts who bring you to therapy to handle all of these ups and downs know you, the Sally who is not a part?

- *Focusing on introducing the system to the client's Self.*

If the Answer is No

THERAPIST: Okay. Then I must be missing something important here. Would it be okay for us to be curious for a moment about why it's hard to promise continuity between sessions to a part like the one from last week?

- *Observing the phenomenon of changing topics and being curious.*



Persistence and curiosity are key to responding when protectors take evasive action. Assume they have legitimate concerns, which they will (eventually) share if you are open-minded and open-hearted with them.

POLARIZED PARTS

Protective parts view vulnerability and the emotional pain of feeling unlovable as the problem. Some parts work proactively to prevent this pain from reaching consciousness; others work reactively to suppress and distract once the pain has reached consciousness. Either way, as they try to solve the problem of emotional suffering they routinely come up with contradictory strategies and get into disagreements. We call parts who disagree over how to hide or manage vulnerability “polarized protectors” – each tries to influence the client’s behavior in different directions.

We know what these parts share: both are trying to solve the problem of emotional pain, both are failing and both stand to gain if we can offer an effective new option. Consequently, we can afford to be hope merchants: we really do have an option that will solve their problem and allow them to retool.

Exercise

NEGOTIATING BILATERAL D ISARMAMENT WITH POLARIZED PARTS

Ask your inner system:

- “Please let me hear all opinions about this problem, taking turns. I will write down what you say.”

Write down everything you hear, noticing contradictions or disagreements (polarities).

Ask these parts:

- “Which part, or team of parts, needs my attention first?”

Then go back to the cornerstone question:

- “How do you feel toward [the target part]?”

If the answer is a C word that indicates Self-energy (see 8C's in glossary), then proceed with interviewing the target part using the 6F's. If the answer is anything else, then another part is reacting. Help that part unblend (differentiate) so that you can interview the target part.

HANDLING THE POLARITIES OF EXTREME PROTECTORS

Often the external environments of trauma survivors are unstable and chaotic. But when protectors are extreme even though the client's life seems stable, we can surmise that something inside feels dangerous. We do not expect or demand trust from extreme protectors – we ask them for the opportunity to earn their trust. Our goal is to persuade extreme protectors to try something new – with the key word being *persuade*. Since these parts are already feeling pressured to change internally, they are hypersensitive to outside efforts at control. To win their interest, we start by validating: “I understand why you do what you do;” and we abdicate control: “You are the boss.”

At the same time, we reassure vigilant parts:

- “You are not your job. If you stop doing this job you will still exist and you would be free.”

We also invite:

- “If you didn't have to do this job anymore, what would you rather do?”

We offer hope:

- “With your permission, we can help the vulnerable part to stop overwhelming.”

And we make an offer:

- “I can show you an effective alternative that comes with a lot of benefits – all you have to do is meet the client's Self.”

Throughout, our challenge is to be with any of our own parts who get stirred up by the client so that we can remain clear and confident. In addition, if an extreme protector (for example, the client is clearly dissociating or reports that everything is blank) won't relax and separate because it believes the client is an endangered child, we can move to direct access (“Can I talk to this part directly?”). We often use direct access with clients who have been diagnosed with dissociative identity disorder (DID), which we in IFS see as a series of extreme polarities that share the goal of keeping feelings and the Self out of awareness at all costs.

TWO EXAMPLES OF POLARITIES

Before we zero in on the exile, IFS therapy tracks relationships between protectors. Here are two different examples, the first illustrates a polarity between two protective parts; the second illustrates a polarity between the protector of a 4-year-old and a teenage part who has her own agenda.

WORKING WITH POLARIZED PROTECTORS WHO WON'T UNBLEND

When one protector doesn't want the client to hear from another protector, it will interfere. Jeremy's conflict, illustrated below, is between a pot smoking part and a worrying part.

Feel Toward

THERAPIST: How do you feel toward the part who worries, Jeremy? It's especially worried about you smoking pot these days, isn't it?

JEREMY: I hate that part.

- *A reactive secondary part, probably the pot smoker.*

Protector Fears

THERAPIST: Okay. If the one who hates it were to relax and let you talk to the worried part, what is it concerned would happen?

JEREMY: The worried part would take over and worrying would be my life!

- *A polarity between the worried part and the pot smoker.*

THERAPIST: And then what?

JEREMY: All work, no play! Anxious. Boring.

- *The pot smoker is blended.*

THERAPIST: Is this the pot smoker talking?

JEREMY: Yeah. I guess so.

THERAPIST: If the worried part were to agree not to take you over, would the pot smoker let you be curious and find out more about its worries?

- *Negotiating for both sides of the polarity to unblend simultaneously.*

JEREMY: The pot smoker says that will never work. It's either him or me.

Hope Merchant

THERAPIST: I'm confident it's worth asking the worried part not to take over. Will the pot smoker give us permission?

- *Being persistent and persuasive.*

JEREMY: It says okay. Suit yourself.

THERAPIST: Great. So ask the worried part if it's willing to not take over if the pot smoker relaxes, too.

- *Asking a part not to overwhelm.*

JEREMY: It says yes, but it's going to stay close and watch.

THERAPIST: Great, then let's invite them both to sit down with you at a conference table. Make sure you're there with them rather than seeing yourself with them.

- *Checking to see if the client's Self is present.*

JEREMY: I see myself at the table with them.

- *This is a "Self-like part" – a protector who stands in for the client's Self.*

THERAPIST: Okay. Ask the part who's sitting in for you to move over one and let you be at the head of the table. Is that okay?

JEREMY: It's not sure who I am.

The Client's Parts Don't Know the Self Yet.

THERAPIST: Let's introduce you. But you can only be there if this part – and the other two parts – let you. It's up to them. Are they willing?

- *Being persistent and persuasive.*

JEREMY: Okay. It moved over and I'm there with the three of them.

Find

THERAPIST: Great. Ask who needs your attention first.

- *Ceding control to the client's parts.*

JEREMY: The worried part.

Feel Toward

THERAPIST: How do you feel toward the worried part now?

JEREMY: I feel curious. What's it so worried about?

- *The client's Self is now available.*



The scenario illustrated here is very common. When we help polarized parts we are, in essence, doing couple therapy with two parts who are in a heated argument that may have gone on for years. Additionally, we see in this example that Jeremy has an active Self-like part who inserts himself initially in the place of Jeremy's Self. This, too, is common. When a hot conflict stirs up inner fears, it can seem to protectors like no time to try something new. Our job is to argue just the opposite.

EXPLORING A POLARITY BETWEEN THE PROTECTOR OF A YOUNG EXILE AND AN EXILED TEENAGER

Georgiana came to therapy because she had fallen in love with a woman in her law firm and was considering ending her marriage – which she had not yet told her wife. They had one son in high school and another in college.

GEORGIANA: I'm losing my mind. My job is to take care of my family. I have children. But Ellen and I don't have a sexual relationship anymore and I'm in love with someone else.

Find

THERAPIST: Okay, who needs your attention first? The one who takes care of the family or the one who's in love?

GEORGIANA: In love.

Feel Toward

THERAPIST: How do you feel toward that part?

GEORGIANA: I feel sorry for her.

THERAPIST: What does she want you to know?

GEORGIANA: Life is short.

THERAPIST: Anything else?

GEORGIANA: She really means it. Life is too short not to live to the fullest.

THERAPIST: Do you understand?

GEORGIANA: Yes.

Flesh Out

THERAPIST: Can you see her?

GEORGIANA: Yes.

THERAPIST: How old is she?

GEORGIANA: She's 18.

THERAPIST: What is her relationship with the part who takes care of the family?

GEORGIANA: They don't agree.

- *That is, the caretaking part, a protector, is polarized with the teenager, who has been exiled in her relationship with her wife. The therapist assumes the caretaking part protects another (probably younger) exile.*

THERAPIST: Okay. I get that. They don't agree. Can we talk to the caretaking part now?"

- *The therapist's goal is to befriend both sides of this polarity and convince both to unblend so that Georgiana can find out why the caretaking part works so hard.*

GEORGIANA: Okay.

Feel Toward

THERAPIST: How do you feel toward your caretaking part?

- *Assessing her level of Self-energy.*

GEORGIANA: What kind of lawyer would I be without her? I love her.

THERAPIST: How does she respond?

GEORGIANA: She likes that.

Befriend

THERAPIST: Tell her you're here to help.

GEORGIANA: She's shaking her head. She can't imagine what I have to offer.

- *This part does not yet know Georgiana's Self.*

THERAPIST: How old does she think you are?

- *The answer to this question will tell us about the exile who she protects.*

GEORGIANA: Well, she thought I was a little kid but now she's not so sure.

- *Georgiana's caretaking part is now beginning to see the Self rather than the little kid she protects.*

THERAPIST: Would she like to find out more about you?

- *Befriending will help the protector to see Georgiana's Self.*

GEORGIANA: Okay.

THERAPIST: Ask her to look you in the eye and tell you who she sees there.

- *Eye contact is often a powerful way of detecting blended parts and introducing the Self.*

GEORGIANA: Oops. She's mad at me.

THERAPIST: Say more.

GEORGIANA: She's saying "Where have you been?!"

- *This response confirms that the caretaking part sees the Self.*

THERAPIST: And what do you say?

GEORGIANA: I'm sorry I wasn't there when she needed me. I didn't mean to leave her alone.

THERAPIST: What was it like for her to be alone?

- *Finding out more about her experience.*

GEORGIANA: She had to act like she wasn't scared.

THERAPIST: What was hardest about that for her?

GEORGIANA: She was alone.

THERAPIST: Do you get that, Georgiana?

GEORGIANA: Yes. It was a scary time.

THERAPIST: Who does she protect?

- *Clarifying the caretaking part's protective role.*

GEORGIANA: A 4-year-old.

- *This is the exile who is being protected by the caretaker.*

THERAPIST: And how old is the caretaker?

- *The therapist asks this question because protective parts are often close in age to the parts who they protect. Sometimes a protector will say it is "old," which often means it has been around since the part it protects was hurt many years ago.*

GEORGIANA: She's like... 8 years old.

THERAPIST: If you could take care of the 4-year-old instead of her, what would she rather do?

- *Introducing the idea that this protector will be liberated along with the 4-year-old.*

GEORGIANA: She likes playing soccer.

THERAPIST: Great. So we can help her do that.

Protector Fears

GEORGIANA: She doesn't think so.

- *This is a typical initial response from a protector.*

THERAPIST: What does she think would happen if she didn't do this job?

- *Eliciting fears.*

GEORGIANA: Chaos. My life will be ruined. No one will like me.

- *This is the fear – it was valid once.*

THERAPIST: She makes sure people like you?

- *Stating the part's job succinctly.*

GEORGIANA: Yes.

THERAPIST: What happens if someone doesn't like you?

- *Exploring protector fears.*

GEORGIANA: It's not okay.

THERAPIST: What's the worst thing about it?

- *Eliciting the part's specific fear.*

GEORGIANA: I'll be alone.

THERAPIST: We don't want you do be alone, either. What do you say to her?

- *This question will reveal how unblended Georgiana is now from the caretaking part.*

GEORGIANA: I know she had reason to be afraid but I'm grown up now and we won't be alone. I'm thanking her for working so hard.

THERAPIST: Does she want your help?

- *Getting permission to help her.*

GEORGIANA: It would be a relief but she doesn't think I really know what I'm up against.

- *Still on protector fears.*

THERAPIST: Would she be willing to get to know you better?

- *Focusing on the part being in relationship with the Self.*

GEORGIANA: She's not sure what the point is but she's willing.

THERAPIST: If she's willing, she doesn't have to believe in anything. This is just an experiment. She can always go back to what she does so well – making sure people like you.

- *Making the offer of change low risk and low cost.*

GEORGIANA: Okay.

THERAPIST: Great. And will she please let you know about any concerns she has along the way?

- *Inviting vigilant parts to object proactively so they feel welcome and included.*

GEORGIANA: But now the 18-year-old is saying “Hey! What about me?”

- *A mistake: the therapist should have checked in with this part as well to reassure her and get permission to proceed with the exiled little girl.*

THERAPIST: I’m sorry. I forgot to check with her. Is it okay with her if you help the 4-year-old?

- *Asking for permission.*

GEORGIANA: How would that help her?

THERAPIST: Would it be good for her if the 4-year-old and the 8-year-old felt safe?

- *Pointing out potential gains for the teenager if she cooperates.*

GEORGIANA: Yeah. It would be good.

THERAPIST: And you can help her, too. What does she need from you?

- *Facilitating the relationship between the teenager and the Self.*

GEORGIANA: Well, she’s in love. She wants everyone to get out of her way.

THERAPIST: Do you get that?

- *Not taking a side but continuing to facilitate the relationship between the Self and the teenager before returning to the conflict between teenager and the caretaking part.*

GEORGIANA: I do. I think she’s a lucky duck.



Georgiana’s presenting problem is an intense inner disagreement about a life-changing decision. The parts involved have strong opposing ideas about what is best for her (they

are polarized). One part (Georgiana's caretaker) has exiled the other part (the teenager) because she feels threatened by her sexuality and passion. The caretaker has also exiled the vulnerable 4-year-old part who she protects. We have yet to hear the 4-year-old's story.

The therapist's goals at this point are to convey respect for the perspectives and concerns of the polarized parts, the caretaker and the teenager, and to facilitate their relationships with Georgiana's Self. When they unblend and Georgiana has the opportunity to heal the 4-year-old, the IFS therapist trusts Georgiana will be able to sort out her love life.

Exercise

INTRODUCING A PROTECTOR TO THE SELF

DIRECTIONS: Think of some situation that has occurred during your life in which you felt threatened and had the impulse to defend yourself – this does not have to be something extreme. It can be recent or from the more distant past.

Take a moment to imagine yourself back in that moment in time.

- You will have an action urge - notice where it is located and what your body wants to do.
 - If you are alone and feel comfortable moving, go ahead and make that gesture.
 - Or picture yourself making that gesture in your mind's eye.
- ◊ Repeat the gesture a few times.

Ask your protector how long it has been doing this job. Write down what you hear.

Ask your protector what it believes would happen if it stopped doing its job. Write down what you hear.

Ask your protector who it protects. Write down what you hear. Sometimes protectors are reluctant to share who they protect. Don't push them, find out what they need in order to trust you more.

If it did share who it protects, set an intention to do so, write that down here and work with the vulnerability in a way that is familiar to you.

If your protector is uncomfortable sharing with you who it protects, stay curious (or, if you are not curious, help reactive parts to differentiate) and inquire about what they need to trust you more.

- If it says something along the lines of: “You will be overwhelmed by that vulnerable part,” thank it and ask for permission to communicate with the part about not being overwhelming.
 - Then ask the exile if, in return for getting the attention it needs, it would be willing to stay separate and not overwhelm.
- If it says: “You are not capable of helping that part” ask it if it would be willing to try an experiment to get to know you better.
 - Ask it how old it thinks you are.
 - Ask it if it is willing to meet the you of today, your Self.
 - Give it time to check you out and get to know you.
 - See if it is willing to look you in the eyes.
 - Ask it, “What is it like to meet me?”
 - And, “Can I have your permission now to help that vulnerable part?”

We all have protective parts who work too hard for us - including the ones who cause us to be “lazy” and unmotivated. In our view, we should declare a yearly national holiday along the lines of Labor Day to honor our protectors, whose efforts on our behalf are often nothing short of heroic. To appreciate the full range of their strategies, here is a list of common protector roles, which by no means exhausts the possibilities.

Introducing A Protector and the Self

- Meet Your Inner Shame Protectors
- Meet Your External Shame Protectors
- Meet Your Compliant Protectors
- Meet Your Anxious Protectors
- Meet Your Dissociative Protectors
- Meet Your Appearance Protectors
- Meet Your Somatizing Protectors
- Meet Your Intimacy Protectors
- Meet Your Food Protectors
- Meet Your Mood-Altering Protectors
- Meet Your Mindfulness Protectors
- Meet Your Sex Addict Protectors
- Meet Your Power Broker Protectors
- Meet Your Success Protectors
- Meet Your Keep-a-Low-Profile Protectors
- Meet Your (exiled) Angry Protectors
- Meet Your Religious Protectors
- Meet Your Political Protectors
- Meet Your Self-Harm Protectors
- Meet Your Suicidal Protectors
- Meet Your Revenge Protectors
- Meet Your Exercise Protectors
- Meet Your Electronic Gadgets Protectors

- Meet Your Intellectual Protectors
- Meet Your Entertainment Protectors
- Meet Your Humor Protectors

Template

MEET YOUR PROTECTOR EXERCISES

DIRECTIONS: Use this template to get to know your protectors. Look over our list of common protector roles and add any we don't mention that are relevant for you.

Notice if this protector is proactive for you (trying to stop feelings from arising) or reactive for you (trying to distract from feelings).

Once you have permission to get to know this protector, ask:

What does it believe would happen if it stopped doing its job? Write down what you hear.

Who does it protect? Write down what you hear.

Ask for permission to help the part it protects.

If it did share who it protects, set an intention to do so, write that down here and work with the vulnerability in a way that is familiar to you.

If your protector is uncomfortable giving you permission to help that part, stay curious.

- Or, if you are not curious, help your reactive parts to unblend and ask why.

If it says something along the lines of: “You will be overwhelmed by that vulnerable part,” ask for permission to ask the exile to not overwhelm.

- Then ask the exile if, in return for getting the attention it needs, would it be willing to stay differentiated and not overwhelm.

If it says: “You are not capable of helping that part,” ask it if it would be willing to get to know you better.

- Then ask it to look you in the eye and let you know who it sees there.

If it sees a reactive part, take a moment to help that part differentiate.

If it sees some quality of Self, ask, “What is it like to meet me?”

- And, “Do I have your permission now to help that vulnerable part who you protect?”

Meet Your Inner Critics

These parts are our ad hoc continual improvement committee. They are relentlessly vigilant, critical, often humorless and usually unpopular with other parts in the system.

- Ask if any other parts are scared of this critic
- If so, help those parts by listening to their concerns and asking if they would be willing to wait in a soundproof room while you talk to the critic
- Alternatively, you can put the critic into a room and then help the scared parts to relax back and trust you

Meet Your Outer Critics

These parts externalize blame. They use all manner of prejudices that involve “othering” to help us feel acceptable, included, safe and important. They are:

- Racist
- Homophobic
- Transphobic
- Misogynist
- Xenophobic

Meet Your Compliant Protectors

These parts try to keep us connected and in the loop, they often make us think of the welfare of others before letting us take care of ourselves. They are:

- People pleasers
- Caretakers

Meet Your Anxious Protectors

These parts want to forestall negative surprises, they want to be sure we don't get hurt and we don't fail, they want to be sure we're not oblivious or naive and innocent. They are:

- Anticipatory
- Often very physical
- Hard to ignore
- Alarmed about imaginary catastrophes
- Full of warnings

Meet Your Dissociative Protectors

These parts take us out either to prevent or to suppress the negative feelings of exiled parts or the reactivity of other, more extreme protectors. They do things like:

- Cloud the mind
- Take us out of time and awareness completely
- Interfere with our ability to hear what others say
- Interfere with our ability to notice danger

- Numb the body so we don't feel that little electric shock with each reminder of frightening experiences
- Ally with parts who take prescribed medications to dull the nervous system
- Ally with parts who self-medicate with illegal drugs or alcohol
- Ally with parts who numb the body with food

Meet Your Appearance Protectors

These parts keep us focused on how we look to others. They want us to have attention, approval, safety and love. They do things like:

- Criticize our looks
- Invite others to criticize our looks
- Encourage us to go shopping
- Fantasize ideal scenarios
- Warn us about negative scenarios
- Obsess over clothing and material goods
- Haunt the mirror

Meet Your Somatizing Protectors

These protectors use the body to get our attention, to influence our behavior, to get attention for us from others, to try to communicate something important about our past experience or the nature of our pain, and generally to promote their agendas. They do things like:

- Give us migraine headaches
- Make us feel nauseated
- Make us hypersensitive to smells
- Make us feel exhausted
- Amplify asthma and allergic reactions
- Give us chest pain

Meet Your Intimacy Protectors

These parts manage and regulate closeness in relationships to protect us from being too vulnerable and getting hurt. They do things like:

- Cultivate an angry edge that keeps us from wanting to be close to anyone and vice versa
- Act needy and overly attached
- Act overly sexual
- Act disinterested
- Act sleepy
- Act bored and disengaged
- Daydream when someone else is talking
- Ally with parts who focus on food or alcohol in social settings
- Ally with parts who focus on electronic gadgets

Meet Your Food Protectors

These parts obsess about food, either indulging or restricting as a way of distracting us from noticing exiled feelings or suppressing those feelings when they come up strongly. They do things like:

- Feel hungry
- Long for and obsess about certain comfort foods
- Overeat
- Restrict
- Fear and avoid certain foods
- Feel sick after eating certain foods
- Restrict calories
- Binge
- Purge

Meet Your Mood-Altering Protectors

These parts use mood-altering substances, legal or illegal, to numb, avoid or distract us from emotional pain and inner conflict. They do things like:

- Drink alcohol
- Smoke pot
- Snort or smoke cocaine

- Take ecstasy and other party drugs
- Snort or shoot heroin
- Sniff glue
- Take prescribed mood-altering pills
- Take unprescribed (or prescribed) mood-altering medication

Meet Your Mindfulness Protectors

These parts use meditation to bypass threatening feelings, fill a sense of emptiness, or as a facsimile for dissociating. They do things like:

- Encourage us to disconnect from all thoughts and feelings
- Dissociate
- Keep our mental processes abstract or vague
- Distract us from emotional pain with hyper- or hypo-focusing
- Encourage us to be stoic
- Encourage us to think instead of feel

Meet Your Sex Addict Protectors

These parts are adept at seduction and spend their time recruiting lovers to pack inner emptiness with drama and attempts at connection. They focus on:

- Sexual attraction
- Longing and desire
- Games of seduction
- Passionate sex when reuniting after quarrels (make-up sex)
- The physiologic release of orgasm

Meet Your Power Broker Protectors

These parts are into power. Their goal is to dominate. They love being in control. They do things like:

- Keep vulnerability out of sight at all costs
- Blame vulnerable parts for getting us hurt
- Attack and shame other people who display vulnerability

Meet Your Success Protectors

These protectors want us to become rich or successful, to feel admired and never feel rejected.

These parts do things like:

- Promote a grandiose sense of our value inside and interpersonally to counter the worthlessness of our exiles and the shaming of our inner critics
- Promote the idea that failure is terrible
- Deny mistakes or failure
- Punish others - particularly our children - for making mistakes or failing
- Avoid apologizing

Meet Your Keep-a-Low-Profile Protectors

These parts do not like us to be seen, to compete, or to threaten others in any way. They keep us invisible, safely under the radar. They do things like:

- Promote the feeling that attention is dangerous
- Avoid letting us be seen
- Discourage ambition
- Refuse to strive for any goal
- Avoid letting us feel good about accomplishments
- Warn us that others will be hurt by our success

Meet Your (exiled) Angry Protectors

Parts who felt angry at mistreatment are often young. They may have stepped forward to protect another young part and been exiled because their anger was unsafe. They often continue to be treated like Kryptonite in the system because anger itself is viewed as a perpetrator behavior. They:

- Smolder
- Resent
- Interrupt
- Push
- Disdain

- Explode

Meet Your Religious Protectors

Some protectors help us overuse religion, idealize religious leaders, long for redemption, long for community, meaning and purpose in life, and care about belonging at the expense of a sense of self and connection to people who are different. These parts:

- Make us feel right
- Make us feel held
- Banish doubt
- Distract from a sense of emptiness and loneliness

Meet Your Political Protectors

Like religious protectors, our political protectors help us find leaders, belong, have community, purpose and structure when feeling empty and alone. These parts:

- Make us feel our side is right
- Make us feel righteous and superior
- Explain right and wrong
- Banish doubt

Meet Your Self-Harm Protectors

These parts cut, scratch, hit and burn to punish, distract, soothe, try to get help, forestall suicide or rage. They do things like:

- Distract from emotional pain
- Shift focus due to the need to tend to injuries
- Concretize emotional pain in blood
- Help us feel alive through pain
- Recruit others to respond to our physical injuries and care for our body

Meet Your Suicide Protectors

The idea of suicide is often a comfort to people who are in extreme pain, emotional or physical. These parts:

- Offer a theoretical (soothing to think about) exit from unending and seemingly insoluble suffering
- Offer an actual (emergency) exit from unending and seemingly insoluble suffering
- Promote the ultimate escape
- Want revenge
- Seek attention
- Want others to react or rescue

Meet Your Revenge Protectors

When we are mistreated, rendered helpless by someone more powerful, humiliated, or made to feel worthless one common response is to want revenge. These parts:

- Are vindictive
- Use sarcasm to gain power
- Try to even the playing field
- Humiliate anyone who feels threatening
- Preoccupy us with fantasies of being powerful and taking revenge, which in the extreme can include hurting or killing someone else

Meet Your Exercise Protectors

These parts often work in conjunction with parts who obsess about our appearance. They can also pinch hit for eating disorder parts. They do things like:

- Hound us to exercise
- Hyper-focus on health
- Urge us to achieve new fitness goals
- Become panicky when we are ill or injured
- Critique the body for imperfections
- Admire bodies that are shown in fashion or sport magazines

Meet Your Electronic Gadgets Protectors

We now have a whole new dimension, a veritable looking-glass world, into which we can fall for endless distraction. Since for most people work and communication depend on electronic

instruments like cell phones and computers, our parts who seek to distract us in this way operate virtually no holds barred with endless options. These parts do things like:

- Take us out when we are at the office
- Take us out when we stand in a line
- Take us out when we are in unpleasant environments like airports, elevators, and busy, noisy public streets
- Take us out when we are in conversation
- Take us out at meals
- Take us out in school, at lectures, in libraries
- In short, they are available to take us out anywhere, anytime

Meet Your Intellectual Protectors

These parts flourish in families and settings that celebrate and survive on the cognitive strengths (e.g., the child of a professor who grows up in a university town). They do things like:

- Think as a way of overriding or interrupting feelings
- Look down on people who don't rely on thinking parts as much
- Help us feel special
- Value knowledge and achievement over feelings and intuition

Meet Your Entertainment Protectors

Netflix anyone? The human mind is engaged by stories, whether they are banal and cliched or original. Our electronic devices deliver an endless stream of visuals, words, music, real and fictional stories. These parts do things like:

- Take us out to the movies, watching TV, cable or various other subscriber services
- Live vicariously through movie characters and retell the stories of the shows we have just watched
- Provide false hopes via reality TV
- Relate to the characters depicted therein to learn, emulate and make sense of experience

Meet Your Humor Protectors

These parts use humor in all kinds of ways to set a tone and influence others. They do things like:

- Keep others happy and engaged
- Please
- Entertain
- Get attention for us
- Provide a distraction from painful or uncomfortable moments
- Cover up feelings
- Distract from feelings internally
- Injure others so they will move away from us
- Exact revenge

Exercise

AN ENDLESS SUPPLY OF PROTECTIVE STRATEGIES

DIRECTIONS: The protectors who often show up in traumatized individuals include dissociation, inner and outer shamers, overwork, keeping-a-low-profile, compliance, anxiety, rage, revenge, suicide, sex addiction, mood-altering substances, intimacy-seeking and intimacy-avoidant, eating, exercise, appearance obsession, somatizing, and intellectualizing.

If you notice protectors in your system who are missing from our list, add them below:

A large rectangular box with a double-line border. Inside, there are seven horizontal lines for writing, spaced evenly.